



Terminal tailspin: Pakistan is no longer a side that can treat talent as a sustainable resource, as Salman Agha's fall from captain to being sent home from England in 12 days illustrated. AFP

I returned later, in 2016 as the Director of Academies, and I continued till May 31, 2020.

During my second stint, the NCA had been revamped, and we started using it properly. It paid dividends. I can name so many players who came through that system — Mohammed Amir, Shaheen Shah Afridi, Naseem Shah, Muhammad Hasnain and Haider Ali to name a few. At one time, most of the

Pakistan team had come from the NCA setup.

It was a great initiative.

But development costs money. As soon as I came out of Pakistan, they would stop giving that money to whoever was in charge. Sooner or later, they would close it down.

The same thing happened to the academies in Multan and Karachi. The facilities were there, especially in Karachi, but instead of improving

them year by year, they let them deteriorate.

That is what happens when development is treated as a programme rather than a long-term system.

The domestic game needs somewhere to breathe

In Pakistan, the cricket season is 12 months a year, and we don't even have more than 18 grounds. Those 18 grounds take the burden of First-Class cricket and all the other tournaments — approximately 131 first-class matches across three red-ball tournaments in a standard domestic season. The pitches get very, very tired.

When they become substandard, they affect the cricket we produce. When fast bowlers don't get any help, they have to find other ways to get batsmen out. That is when they start managing the cricket ball.

We have always had decent spinners. But in recent times, there hasn't been a mystery spinner or someone like Abdul Qadir. We have lost that art of producing quality spinners, too.

But the problem starts even before a player reaches First-Class cricket. Club cricket is the most important part of the grassroots structure, and we have neglected it.

When I was growing up, we had a robust club cricket system in Pakistan. In Lahore alone, there were hundreds of clubs taking part in 40- and 50-over tournaments. That was where young cricketers played regularly, competed, improved and got noticed.

Now there are hardly any tournaments because of the lack of clubs and the state of the economy. The PCB has chosen to neglect this important part of the game. The game progressively starts fading.

The PCB constitution clearly says that all regional and district presidents must ensure a minimum of two club tournaments a year. At best, only about 10 per cent deliver this. Yet no questions are asked of these office-bearers because the PCB needs their votes.

That is how the problem becomes